07

PART 7 OF 9

The World of Jesus

MATT, MARK, LUKE, JOHN

From the stable in Bethlehem to the empty tomb in Jerusalem – the landscapes Jesus of Nazareth walked through.



The Land Jesus Knew

Imagine a country you can cross on foot in a few days, yet one that holds nearly every landscape in the world: the green hills of Galilee, the shores of a seaside lake, the hot Jordan Valley, the barren mountains of the Judean Desert, and the rocky ridge on which Jerusalem stands. This is where Jesus' life unfolded. The Gospels do not describe it like a tourist guide, but every place name in them is rooted in real geography that you can find on a map.

From Nazareth to Jerusalem is about 100 km in a straight line, and from Capernaum on the lake to Bethlehem about 150 km. For people of that time this meant several days of walking, usually along the Jordan or through Samaria. Galilee was fertile and densely populated, Judea harsher, and above it all rose Jerusalem with the Temple. Once you know these distances and differences in elevation, many Gospel scenes take on unexpected concreteness: weariness at a well, a storm on the lake, the climb up from Jericho.

In this part we will visit twelve places, from Bethlehem to Golgotha and the road to Emmaus. For each you will find a short summary of the event, an explanation of why location and terrain matter, and an artistic reconstruction based on archaeological knowledge. Where a location rests on tradition, we say so clearly. Read with your Bible in hand: references follow the Millennium Bible, and we retell the Gospel texts in our own words.

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HOW TO USE THIS PART

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

MAP 7.1

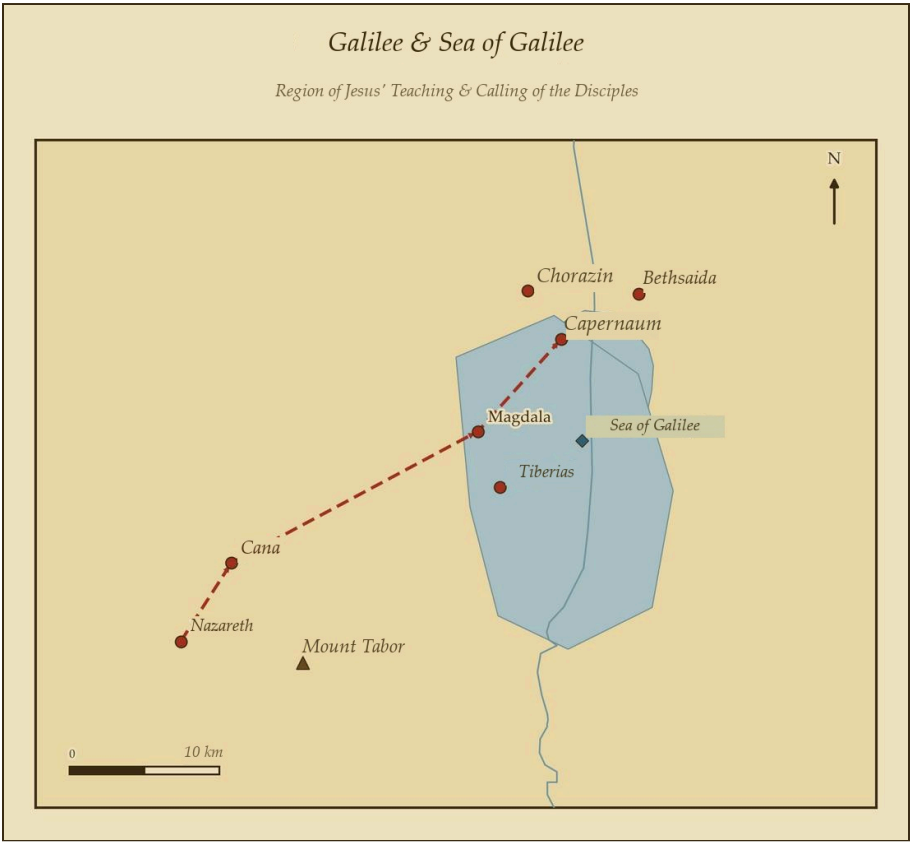


The map shows the main places of Jesus' ministry, from the northern sources of the Jordan to Bethlehem in the south. The lines mark the two most common routes between Galilee and Jerusalem.

Note how small this area is: from Caesarea Philippi to Bethlehem it is about 190 km in a straight line. Even so, Jesus passed through three different regions, each with its own climate and people. Samaria lay in the middle, and many people

avoided it because of tensions. The Jordan Valley was a longer but calmer route. The map shows that the great events of the Gospels unfold within a few days' walk.

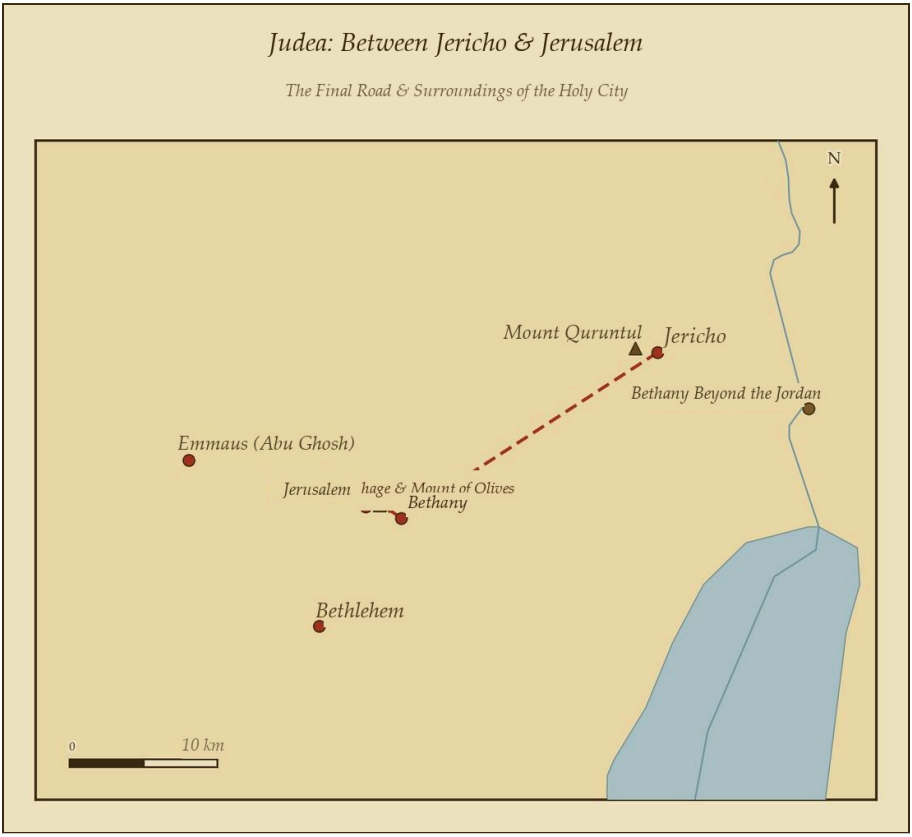
MAP 7.2



The map shows lower and northern Galilee with the towns around the lake. The blue area is the Sea of Galilee, and the line shows the road from Nazareth to Capernaum.

Almost all the towns where Jesus taught most often lay near the lake, within a dozen or so kilometers of Capernaum. Chorazin, Bethsaida and Capernaum formed a northern cluster of settlements that Jesus rebuked because, despite the miracles, they did not repent (Matt 11:20–24). Tabor stands apart on the plain, like a natural landmark. This makes it easy to understand how quickly news spread.

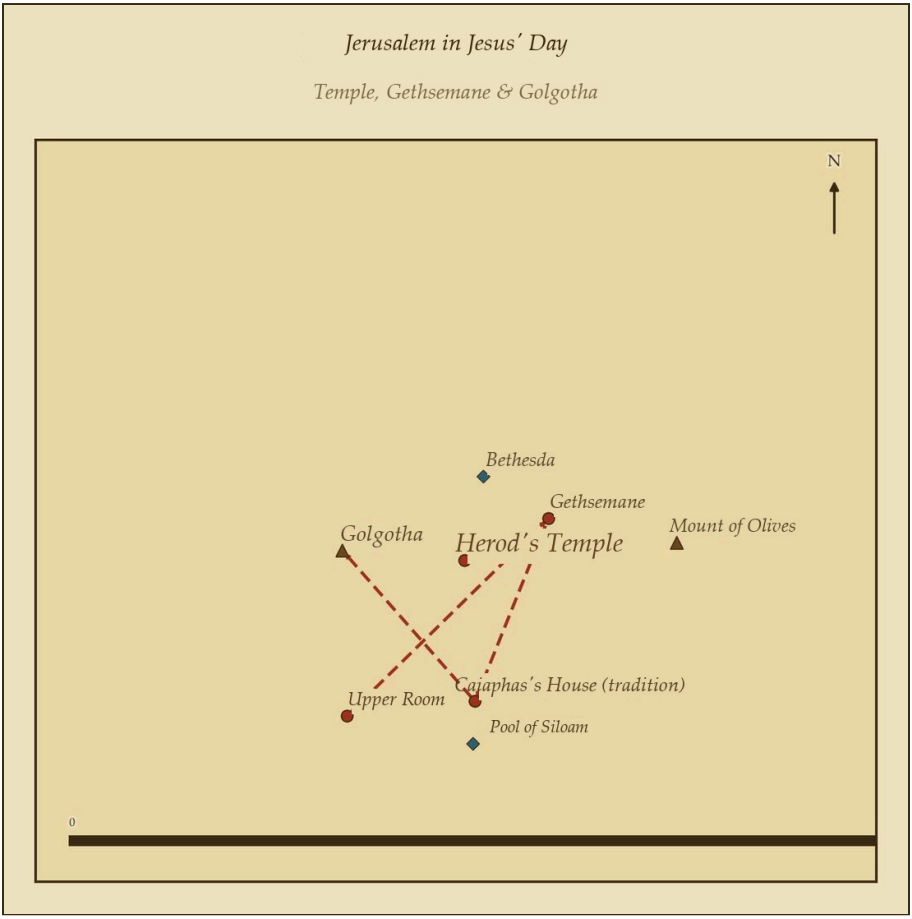
MAP 7.3



The map covers Judea from Bethlehem in the south to Jericho in the east. The line shows the road Jesus took before entering Jerusalem.

The road from Jericho to Jerusalem climbs about 1,000 m over just 27 km, so pilgrims had to work hard. Bethany and Bethphage lay right by the Mount of Olives, which explains why Jesus stayed there during Passion Week. Emmaus is marked traditionally, but its location remains a subject of research.

MAP 7.4



The map shows the most important places in Jerusalem connected with the last days of Jesus. The route is simplified, and some locations rest on tradition.

Jerusalem occupied hills surrounded by valleys: the Kidron on the east and the Hinnom on the south, which gave the city natural defense. The Temple dominated the east, and Golgotha lay just outside the walls. The distances are small; all the places lie within about 2 km. This makes it easy to see how quickly the events of Holy Week followed one another.

01 Bethlehem

MATT 2; LUKE 2:1–20

The City of David, where Jesus was born.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

In Jesus' day Bethlehem was a small farming village of stone houses with flat roofs. Many of them were built against natural caves, used as stables and storerooms. Flocks grazed on the slopes, and in the evening the air quickly turned cool. It was a quiet corner rather than a bustling town (artistic reconstruction).

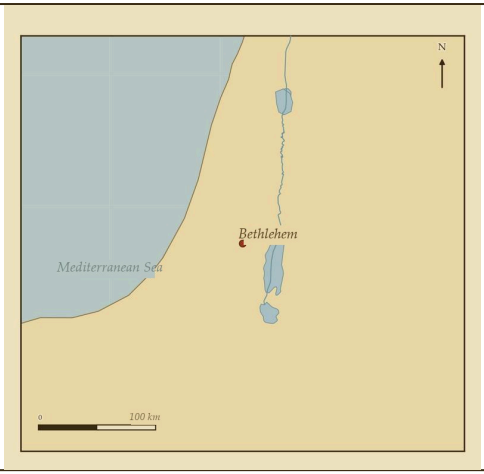
7.1 · BETHLEHEM · MATT 2; LUKE 2:1–20

The Gospels tell how Joseph, a descendant of the house of David, set out from Nazareth for Bethlehem to be registered in the census. There Mary gave birth to her Son and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them at the inn. That night shepherds guarding their flocks in the nearby fields heard the news and went to see the child. Later, according to Matthew, wise men from the East arrived, guided by a star, and presented their gifts. A deadly threat from King Herod forced the family to flee to Egypt.

Bethlehem lies about 8 km south of Jerusalem, on a ridge of hills rising about 770 m above sea level. Pastures stretch around it, sloping toward the Judean Desert, ideal for flocks of sheep, which explains the presence of shepherds. The journey from Galilee usually took several days and led through the Jordan Valley or Samaria. Its closeness to the capital explains why news of the birth reached Herod. Ancient tradition points to the cave beneath today's Church of the Nativity as the birthplace of Jesus, venerated since the early centuries of Christianity.

FACTS

Distance from Bethlehem to Jerusalem: about 8 km; elevation about 770 m above sea level.


N
Bethlehem
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

02 Nazareth

LUKE 1:26–38; 2:39–52; MATT 2:23

The small town of Jesus' childhood and youth.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

In the first century Nazareth was a small village of probably a few hundred inhabitants. Houses of rough-cut stone and clay stood among terraces of olives, vines and grain. Narrow lanes led to the well and to a simple synagogue. Children helped with the animals and in the fields (artistic reconstruction).

7.2 · NAZARETH · LUKE 1:26–38; 2:39–52; MATT 2:23

According to Luke, it was in Nazareth that the angel Gabriel announced to Mary that she would conceive a Son. After the return from Egypt the family settled in this town, and there Jesus grew up, increasing in wisdom, as Luke records. Joseph worked as a carpenter, and Jesus was known to the townspeople as the carpenter's son. When He returned to Nazareth years later as a teacher, He spoke in the synagogue, reading a passage from the prophet Isaiah, but met with disbelief from His fellow townspeople (Luke 4:16–30).

Nazareth lies in lower Galilee, in a basin surrounded by hills, at about 350 m above sea level. It was not an important town, and the Old Testament does not mention it at all, which explains the skeptical question of whether anything good can come out of Nazareth (John 1:46). Even so, the town lay near busy routes. Only a few kilometers away stood Sepphoris, then being rebuilt as the capital of the region, where craftsmen could find work. As a result, Jesus grew up in an environment open to the wider world.

FACTS

Elevation: about 350 m above sea level; distance to the Sea of Galilee: about 30 km.

03 The Jordan and Bethany Beyond the Jordan

MARK 1:1–11; JOHN 1:28; MATT 3:13–17

The place of Jesus' baptism and the beginning of His public ministry.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The river was then the color of murky green, and its banks were overgrown with reeds, willows and tamarisks. Among the vegetation sat people waiting for their turn, far from the noise of the city. The air was hot and humid, and desert hills could be seen in the background (artistic reconstruction).

7.3 · THE JORDAN AND BETHANY BEYOND THE JORDAN · MARK 1:1–11; JOHN 1:28; MATT 3:13–17

John the Baptist preached repentance by the Jordan, and people from all Judea and Jerusalem came to confess their sins and be baptized. Among them came Jesus of Nazareth. The Gospels agree that after the baptism the heavens opened, the Spirit descended on Him like a dove, and the Father's voice confirmed that He is the beloved Son. The Gospel of John names the place of the baptism as Bethany beyond the Jordan, that is, on the eastern side of the river. It was the beginning of Jesus' public mission.

The Jordan flows in a deep rift valley, and the area around Jericho lies more than 250 m below sea level, in one of the lowest places on earth. In its lower course the river is narrow, winding and surrounded by dense vegetation, which favored gatherings in a secluded place, away from the cities. The spot was convenient also because an important road from Jericho to the eastern lands passed nearby. Today's site of Al-Maghtas, traditionally regarded as Bethany beyond the Jordan, lies about 9 km from the Dead Sea.

FACTS

Elevation: about 250–400 m below sea level; distance to the Dead Sea: about 9 km.


N
Jordan & Bethany Beyond the Jordan
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

04 The Judean Desert

MATT 4:1–11; MARK 1:12–13; LUKE 4:1–13

Forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The desert is a landscape of beige and ochre: rocky hills, ravines and cliffs without a trace of green. By day the heat is intense, by night it is cold. The silence is almost complete, broken only by the sound of the wind. From the high rocks the Dead Sea can be seen glittering below (artistic reconstruction).

Right after His baptism Jesus was led by the Spirit into the desert. The Gospels speak of forty days of fasting and three temptations: bread, a miraculous sign, and power over the kingdoms of the world. Each time Jesus answers by appealing to Scripture. The forty days recall Israel's forty years of wandering in the wilderness, but where the people failed, Jesus remains faithful. For Christians this scene remains to this day the model for Lent.

The Judean Desert occupies a narrow strip between the Judean ridge and the Dead Sea. It stretches about 100 km in length and about 25 km in width, and rainfall here is minimal. The terrain is cut by deep ravines, caves and cliffs, which favored hermits. According to tradition, the place of the temptations was Mount Kuruntul (Latin Quarantana) above Jericho, rising about 350 m above the city. This is a traditional location, because the Gospels do not name a specific peak.

FACTS

Length of the Judean Desert: about 100 km; Mount Kuruntul: about 350 m above Jericho.

05 Cana of Galilee

JOHN 2:1–12; JOHN 4:46–54

The wedding where Jesus performed His first sign.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

A Galilean village of small stone houses was surrounded by terraced vineyards and olive groves. In the wedding courtyard stood stone jars used for ritual washing. Guests sat on rugs, and children ran between the tables. In the evening oil lamps lit the interior (artistic reconstruction).

The Gospel of John tells of a wedding in Cana to which Jesus, His mother and His disciples were invited. When the wine ran out, Mary turned to her Son and told the servants to do whatever He said. Jesus had six stone jars filled with water, and when it was drawn out, it turned out to be wine of excellent quality. John calls this the beginning of signs, which revealed Jesus' glory and strengthened the disciples' faith. Jesus later returned to Cana to heal the son of a royal official.

Cana is traditionally identified with Kafr Kanna, about 6 km northeast of Nazareth, on the road leading to the lake. Archaeologists have also proposed the site of Khirbet Qana, a few kilometers to the north, but this remains a matter of debate among specialists. The location explains why Jesus could easily travel from here to Capernaum: the road down toward the lake ran about 25 km and descended more than 500 m. Wedding celebrations usually lasted several days, and wine was an important part of hospitality.

FACTS

Distance from Cana to Nazareth: about 6 km; to Capernaum: about 25 km.

06 Capernaum

MARK 1:21–34; MARK 2:1–12; MATT 4:13

Jesus' town on the northern shore of the lake.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The town consisted of low houses of dark basalt, packed tightly around shared courtyards. The roofs of branches and clay were flat, and nets dried on the shore. Fishing boats stood at the landing, and the hills of the Golan towered over it all (artistic reconstruction).

7.6 · CAPERNAUM · MARK 1:21–34; MARK 2:1–12; MATT 4:13

Matthew writes that Jesus left Nazareth and made His home in Capernaum by the lake. In this town He called Matthew the tax collector, healed Peter's mother-in-law and taught in the synagogue, and crowds came to His house in such numbers that the friends of a paralyzed man removed the roof to lower the sick man inside (Mark 2:1–12). Many of the fishermen who became disciples lived right here. That is why the town is sometimes called His own town (Matt 9:1).

Capernaum lay on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee, at a crossroads linking Galilee with Syria and the coast. The Via Maris passed through here, so there was a customs post and soldiers were stationed there, such as the centurion in Luke 7. The lake lies about 210 m below sea level. Excavations have uncovered black basalt houses and a later white limestone synagogue. Beneath it older basalt walls were found, and beneath the octagonal church the remains of a house that tradition links with Peter.

FACTS

Lake level: about 210 m below sea level; population in the 1st century: about 1,000–1,500.


N
Capernaum
0
50 km

07 The Sea of Galilee: Magdala, Bethsaida and Tiberias

MARK 4:35–41; MARK 6:45–52; JOHN 6:1–21; LUKE 8:2

The lake where Jesus calmed the storm and fed the crowds.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The boats had low sides and a single sail, and at dawn fishermen hauled in their nets, washed them and mended them. The water could be remarkably calm and deep blue, but in a few moments it could be covered in waves. Beyond rose the peaks of the Golan hills, and in the evening campfires glimmered on the shores (artistic reconstruction).

7.7 · THE SEA OF GALILEE: MAGDALA, BETHSAIDA AND TIBERIAS · MARK 4:35–41; MARK 6:45–52; JOHN 6:1–21; LUKE 8:2

By the Sea of Galilee Jesus called His first disciples, Simon, Andrew, James and John, who were fishing. From a boat He taught the crowds, and during a crossing He calmed a violent storm, asking the disciples about their faith. The multiplication of the loaves and fish and the walking on water also took place by the lake. Magdala was the hometown of Mary Magdalene, Bethsaida the town of Peter, Andrew and Philip, and Tiberias, founded by Herod Antipas, bore the name of an emperor whom the Gospels mention only briefly.

The lake is about 21 km long and about 13 km wide, and lies about 210 m below sea level, surrounded by hills. Cold air from Mount Hermon can rush down toward the water, causing sudden, violent storms, which explains the Gospel scene well. Magdala lay on the western shore, Tiberias a little to the south, and Bethsaida at the mouth of the Jordan on the northern shore. Fishing boats sailed at night, because there were more fish then, and several towns around the lake lived off the catch.

FACTS

Length of the lake: about 21 km; width: about 13 km; level: about 210 m below sea level.


N
Sea of Galilee: Magdala, Bethsaida & Tiberias
Mediterranean Sea

08 Samaria and Sychar

JOHN 4:1–42

Jesus' conversation with the Samaritan woman at Jacob's well.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

At the foot of Mount Gerizim stretched a fertile valley with wheat fields. The well was open, surrounded by a stone curb, from which water was drawn in a leather bucket. At noon it was hot, and the area was almost deserted. In the distance a settlement could be seen (artistic reconstruction).

The Gospel of John tells how Jesus, weary from the journey, sat down by Jacob's well in the Samaritan town of Sychar at midday. He asked for water from a woman who had come to draw it. This was surprising, because Jews and Samaritans rarely met. The conversation concerned living water, true worship and the expectation of the Messiah. The woman told the townspeople about Him, and many of them believed and invited Him to stay for two days.

Samaria lay between Judea and Galilee. The shortest road from Jerusalem to Nazareth was about 100 km and crossed precisely this region, although many Jews chose a longer route along the Jordan to avoid hostility. Sychar is usually identified with the area of today's Askar, at the foot of Mount Gerizim, which was the Samaritans' holy mountain of worship. Jacob's well, about 35 m deep, is still a recognizable site today. This is a traditional location, strongly based on the testimony of ancient pilgrims.

FACTS

Depth of Jacob's well: about 35 m; distance from Jerusalem to Nazareth through Samaria: about 100 km.

09 Caesarea Philippi and the Mount of Transfiguration

MATT 16:13–20; MATT 17:1–9; MARK 9:2–10

Peter's confession at the sources of the Jordan and the revelation of glory on the mountain.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

At Banias water flowed out from beneath a rock face in which niches had been carved for statues. Trees and shrubs covered the area, and the air was cooler than by the lake. Tabor rises alone above the Jezreel plain like a dome, and from its summit you can see fields, hills and distant mountains (artistic reconstruction).

In the region of Caesarea Philippi Jesus asked His disciples who people say He is, and then who they themselves say He is. Peter answered that He is the Messiah, the Son of the living God, and Jesus entrusted him with a special mission in the Church (Matt 16:13–20). A few days later He took Peter, James and John up a high mountain, where His face shone and Moses and Elijah appeared beside Him. A voice from the cloud pointed to Jesus as the beloved Son.

Caesarea Philippi lies at the foot of Mount Hermon, by the springs of Banias, one of the main sources of the Jordan, at about 350 m above sea level. It was a city built by the tetrarch Philip and dedicated to the emperor, with a cave for the worship of the god Pan. The Gospels do not name the Mount of Transfiguration. Christian tradition has long pointed to Tabor in lower Galilee (about 588 m above sea level), but some scholars name Hermon (about 2,814 m above sea level). This location remains a matter of debate, which is why we speak of tradition.

FACTS

Tabor: about 588 m above sea level; Hermon: about 2,814 m above sea level; Caesarea Philippi: about 350 m above sea level.

10 Jericho

MARK 10:46–52; LUKE 19:1–10

The last stop before going up to Jerusalem.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Jericho was a green oasis in the desert. Palm groves, gardens and palaces rose all around, watered by numerous springs. Caravans stopped here before the hard road uphill. Beyond the city began the bare, brown slopes of Judea (artistic reconstruction).

As Jesus approached Jerusalem, He met two people in Jericho. A blind beggar, Bartimaeus, cried out to Him in faith and received his sight. Zacchaeus, chief of the tax collectors, short in stature, climbed a sycamore tree to see Jesus, and Jesus invited Himself to his house. Zacchaeus promised to give half of his wealth to the poor and to repay fourfold what he had extorted. Jesus declared that salvation had come to his house, for He came to seek and to save the lost.

Jericho lies about 250 m below sea level and is one of the oldest cities in the world, but in Jesus' day life was concentrated in Herod's new center, a few kilometers from the old tell. The warm climate allowed palms and balsam to be grown, and the city was wealthy and had a customs post. From here a rocky road about 27 km long led up to Jerusalem, climbing about 1,000 m. It was considered dangerous, and it is in this area that the parable of the Good Samaritan is set.

FACTS

Distance from Jericho to Jerusalem: about 27 km; difference in elevation: about 1,000 m.

11 Jerusalem: Herod's Temple and the Pool of Bethesda

MARK 11:15–17; JOHN 2:13–22; JOHN 5:1–15

The heart of Israel: the Temple and the pool where Jesus healed a sick man.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The Temple gleamed with honey-colored stone and with gold on the front of the sanctuary building. The courts were filled with pilgrims, priests and merchants. Broad steps led to the gates, and colonnades gave shade. Nearby, the pool with its porticoes teemed with sick people seeking relief (artistic reconstruction).

Jesus came to Jerusalem for pilgrimage feasts such as Passover. He taught in the Temple courts, and during one visit He drove the merchants out, saying that God's house is to be a house of prayer. Nearby, at the pool of Bethesda, He met a man who had been lying there for thirty-eight years and had no one to help him into the water. Jesus told him to get up and walk, which coincided with the Sabbath and stirred up a dispute (John 5:1–15).

The Temple was expanded by Herod the Great on a vast raised platform of about 14 hectares, supported by massive walls. Its western wall survives to this day, revered by Jews. The platform towered over the Kidron Valley to the east, so the building was visible from afar, including from the Mount of Olives. The pool of Bethesda lay just north of the Temple, near the Sheep Gate, and excavations have uncovered two large pools with porticoes. This identification is widely accepted today.

FACTS

Area of the Temple platform: about 14 hectares; height of the retaining walls: over 30 m.


N
Jerusalem: Herod's Temple & Pool of Bethesda
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

12 Gethsemane, Golgotha and the Road to Emmaus

MARK 14:32–42; JOHN 19:16–42; LUKE 24:13–35

The garden of prayer, the hill of the cross and the empty tomb.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Gethsemane is a grove of old olive trees, where at night a half-darkness reigns, lit only by torches. Golgotha was a rocky hill by the walls, from which the road leading to the gate could be seen. The garden with a tomb cut in the rock lay right next to it, and Easter morning brought silence and light there (artistic reconstruction).

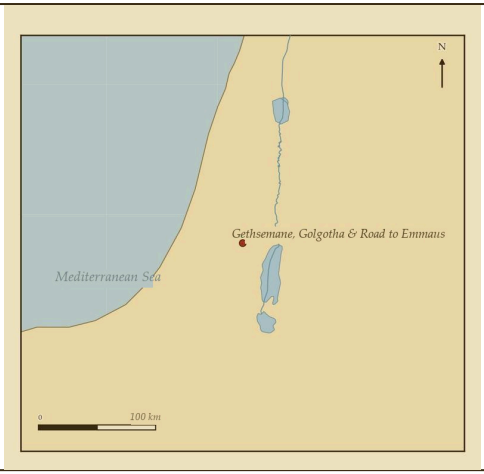
7.12 · GETHSEMANE, GOLGOTHA AND THE ROAD TO EMMAUS · MARK 14:32–42; JOHN 19:16–42; LUKE 24:13–35

After the Last Supper Jesus went with His disciples to a garden called Gethsemane at the foot of the Mount of Olives, where He prayed in anguish, asking the Father that His will be done. There He was seized, tried and condemned. He carried the cross to the hill called Golgotha, where He was crucified. Joseph of Arimathea laid His body in a new tomb in a nearby garden. On the third day the tomb was found empty, and the Risen One appeared to His disciples, among others to two travelers on the road to Emmaus.

Gethsemane lies on the eastern side of the Kidron Valley, opposite the Temple, on the slope of the Mount of Olives, which rises about 800 m above sea level. In Jesus' time Golgotha was outside the city walls, in a former quarry, today within the Church of the Holy Sepulchre. Ancient tradition and excavations allow us to link this place with the crucifixion and burial. The location of Emmaus is disputed; Abu Ghosh and Latrun are among those named, about 11 km from Jerusalem, according to Luke's description about 60 stadia.

FACTS

Distance from Gethsemane to Golgotha: about 1 km; Emmaus (according to Luke): about 60 stadia, or about 11 km from Jerusalem.


N
Gethsemane, Golgotha & Road to Emmaus
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

Questions for Reflection

1. Which of the twelve places described in this part feels closest to you, and why? What changes in your understanding of a scene when you know its geography?

2. Jesus spent most of His life in small towns of Galilee. What does this simplicity say about the way God enters human life?

3. Walk in your mind along Jesus' road from Jericho to Jerusalem and on to Gethsemane. What feelings accompany you at each stage of this journey?